



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A parody party game for people who have seen the bill.

White Cards (Answers)

Printing this deck

450 white cards, nine per page, 50 pages of cards. Each card is 2.5 by 3.5 inches, the same size as a standard playing card.

Print at 100% scale. Turn off "fit to page" and "shrink oversized pages," which will throw off the cut lines. The card pages begin on page 2.

White cards print cheap. This is the only part of the game that is cost optimized.

Cut along the gray grid lines. A paper trimmer will save you roughly an hour of your life compared to scissors.

Where to get the decks

Both decks and the rules live in the project repo:

<https://github.com/michaelgeiser/cards-against-the-cloud/>

Grab the latest files there. Cards get added, retired, and rewritten as new services ship and old ones get deprecated, which in this industry is roughly weekly.

Copyright and license

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The deck is provided as-is. If a card ends a friendship or gets you invited to a conversation with HR, that is between you and the table.

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A NAT Gateway nobody remembers creating  CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	\$47,000 in data transfer charges  CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	us-east-1  CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD
Lambda cold starts  CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	An S3 bucket set to "public: yes, very"  CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	The AWS Free Tier, technically  CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD
Reserved Instances for a workload that no longer exists  CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	Route 53 propagation, allegedly  CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	A CloudFormation stack stuck in DELETE_FAILED since 2021  CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

An EC2 instance named temp-do-not-delete	t2.micro heroism	The Well-Architected Framework, printed and never opened
 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD
Elastic Beanstalk, still somehow alive	A CloudWatch dashboard nobody has ever looked at	CloudWatch logging that costs more than the application
 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD
An SCP that blocks everything, including you	Service quotas you learned about at 2 a.m.	A support case marked Severity: Low during a full outage
 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Kinesis shard math

DynamoDB hot partitions

The AWS console page that also won't load



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CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Six different ways to run a container on AWS

An AWS Snowball being used as a paperweight

A Glacier restore that finishes next Thursday



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CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Athena scanning four terabytes to count rows

An SQS message that has been retried three million times

A dead-letter queue full of forgotten problems



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**EventBridge rules
nobody can trace**



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**AWS Config, generating
findings until the heat death
of the universe**



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**GuardDuty alerting on
your own VPN**



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**Cost Explorer, opened
in horror**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**An IAM policy with
Action: ***



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A Lambda that
recursively invokes itself**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

re:Invent swag



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A keynote demo
available in preview
soon**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**The Solutions Architect
Professional exam**



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AWS Marketplace, where budgets go to die



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An unattached EBS volume from 2019



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

AWS Backup, configured but never tested



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Amazon Q suggesting you open a support case



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A VPC endpoint that would have saved you \$9,000



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Azure



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An Azure blade that opens another blade



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Entra ID, formerly Azure AD, formerly ADFS, formerly pain



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Conditional Access locking out the global admin



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Azure DevOps, which is neither



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Being told to just use a Logic App



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A resource group named rg-test-final-final2



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The Azure pricing calculator, lying to your face



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Microsoft licensing



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An E5 license you were bullied into buying



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Copilot, everywhere, unasked



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A Teams meeting about the Slack migration



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Front Door, Application Gateway, Traffic Manager, and Load Balancer walking into a bar



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**A region named West US 3
for reasons nobody will
explain**



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**Bicep, which is
Terraform with better
marketing**



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**Losing an entire
subscription inside the
tenant**



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**An Azure Function cold
start, which is somehow
worse**



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**Google deprecating it in
eighteen months**



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**A GCP product renamed
twice this quarter**



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**BigQuery, briefly, until
the invoice arrives**



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**Firebase, still the best
thing Google owns**



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Google Cloud Support



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A Google product killed the week you adopted it



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gcloud auth login, forever



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Anthos



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Third place with first-place engineering



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Spanner, which nobody outside Google can afford



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GKE Autopilot doing something you did not ask for



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A Google engineer explaining why your use case is wrong



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OCI



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Oracle's licensing auditors



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**An OCI free tier account
Oracle canceled on its
own**



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Larry Ellison's yacht



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**IBM Cloud, where
COBOL goes to retire**



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**Alibaba Cloud, in
whatever region is legal
today**



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**DigitalOcean,
unironically fine**



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**Linode, may it rest in
peace**



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Rackspace



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**A sovereign cloud that is
one rack in Frankfurt**



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**Being audited by Oracle
for using Java**



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Someone actually completing an OCI migration	The OCI sales rep who will not stop calling	Hetzner, where the real ones go
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On-prem, now rebranded as private cloud	A colocation cage nobody has visited since 2019	Four thousand lines of YAML
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kubectl delete with the wrong context	A Helm chart forked into oblivion	CrashLoopBackOff
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ImagePullBackOff

**An etcd cluster with
exactly two members**

**A service mesh
nobody asked for**



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Istio

**The CNCF landscape
poster**

**Running Kubernetes to
host one WordPress site**



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**An EKS upgrade that
broke every CRD**

**A Docker image that is
4.2 GB of Ubuntu**

latest, as a version tag



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A container that works locally and nowhere else



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Pod eviction at the worst possible moment



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A sidecar with more resources than the actual app



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Kubernetes, honestly



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Terraform state corruption



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terraform apply with no plan



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Configuration drift



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Someone clicking around in the console



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A state file in an S3 bucket with no locking



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**terraform destroy in
production**



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**A module that is
"basically art"**



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**HashiCorp changing
the license**



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**OpenTofu, adopted
purely out of spite**



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**A count that should
have been a for_each**



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**Pulumi, for people who
prefer their pain in
TypeScript**



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**Ansible playbooks with
200 tasks and no
idempotency**



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**Copy-pasting from a
blog post written in 2018**



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**Infrastructure as
Suggestions**



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A pipeline that deploys on merge to a branch nobody watches



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Hardcoded credentials



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An access key on GitHub, discovered in ninety seconds



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Logging in as root, just this once



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A security group open to 0.0.0.0/0



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MFA on a phone that got wiped



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An expired TLS certificate



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Shadow IT



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A shared admin password in a spreadsheet



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passwords_final_v3.xlsx

A pentester with fifteen minutes and a large coffee

Zero Trust, as a slide



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The annual security awareness video

A phishing test you failed twice

The one guy who still has domain admin



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An offboarded employee whose badge still works

Someone's personal AWS account running production

Compliance theater



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**SOC 2, achieved
through vibes**



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**A scanner reporting
40,000 criticals**



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Patching, eventually



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**A firewall rule
commented "temporary -
2017"**



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The default password



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**An API key in a client-
side JavaScript bundle**



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**Rotating secrets, in
theory**



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**A bastion host with the
door propped open**



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**A surprise bill with a
comma you were not
expecting**



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**A direct message from
the FinOps team**



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**Tagging compliance at
twelve percent**



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**Three forgotten dev
environments**



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**A GPU instance left
running over the
holidays**



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Egress charges



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**Cross-AZ traffic you did
not know was cross-AZ**



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**The CFO learning what
elastic means**



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**Paying for high
availability you never
test**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**"We'll optimize it
later"**



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**Buying a tool to tell you
how much you are
overspending**



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**The vendor's ROI
slide**



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**A proof of concept that has
been in production for four
years**



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It's always DNS



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**It was never DNS, but
check anyway**



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**A CNAME pointing at
nothing**



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A TTL of 86400



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**An Elastic Load Balancer
that can't get a response
from the DNS server**



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**A VPC peering mesh
shaped like a spider web**



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Overlapping CIDR ranges



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A Transit Gateway invoice



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BGP



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Someone announcing a prefix they do not own



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A VPN tunnel that flaps every twenty minutes



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NAT, the eternal tax



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IPv6, which we will absolutely get to next quarter



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A proxy that strips the one header you need



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CORS



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A 3:07 a.m. PagerDuty alert	The alert that fires nightly and means nothing	Alert fatigue
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A Sev 1 declared by someone who could not find the login page	A war room bridge with forty people on mute	Adding more people to the call
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A postmortem that concludes "human error"	A blameless postmortem where everyone knows whose fault it was	Action items from the last outage, still open
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**Deploying at 4:45 p.m.
on a Friday**



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**A change freeze
everyone ignores**



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**A status page updated
ninety minutes late**



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**"We are investigating
elevated error rates"**



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**Rolling back to a version
that was also broken**



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**Restarting it and
hoping**



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**The one engineer who
understands it, on PTO**



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**A runbook that says
"contact Dave"**



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Dave, who left in 2022



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Escalating to a vendor's L1 support	Being asked for an ETA ninety seconds in	An executive joining the bridge to ask if it's fixed yet
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The customer who noticed before monitoring did	A migration script with no rollback	DROP TABLE without a WHERE clause
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Eventual consistency	RDS connection pool exhaustion	A single-AZ production database
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The read replica everyone forgot to promote	Backups that have never once been restored	A restore test scheduled for next quarter since 2021
 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD
Nightly full backups of a forty-terabyte warehouse	A stored procedure written in 2004	The index that would have fixed everything
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N+1 queries	MongoDB, web scale	The data lake, now a data swamp
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A Snowflake bill

**An AI agent holding
production credentials**

Prompt injection



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**A chatbot confidently
inventing an AWS
service**

**"We're an AI company
now"**

**A RAG pipeline that
retrieves the wrong
document every time**



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Vibe coding

**An LLM writing the
postmortem for the outage
it caused**

A GPU quota denial



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**Training a model on
your own support tickets**



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**An AI-generated
architecture diagram with
six arrows to nowhere**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Copilot
autocompleting a
secret**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**The AI strategy slide
with no strategy on it**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A demo that worked
because it was pre-
recorded**



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**Replacing a regex with a
70-billion-parameter
model**



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**An agent that opened four
hundred Jira tickets
overnight**



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Hallucinated citations



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**The board asking what
our AI story is**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

An MCP server with no authentication



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AGI, next year, definitely



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A chatbot that solves every problem by apologizing



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A digital transformation initiative



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The reorg



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A meeting that should have been an email



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

An email that should have been nothing at all



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Six weeks of architecture review



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The Architecture Review Board



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A consultant's ninety-page deliverable



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Gartner



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An RFP with four hundred requirements



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A steering committee



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Two competing internal platforms



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The platform team's platform for the platform



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

"We should probably make this event-driven"



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A synergy



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

The offshore team's 11 p.m. handoff



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A Jira ticket from 2019 titled "investigate"	Story points used as a unit of time	Velocity
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A Confluence page with one sentence and a broken image	Documentation	A README that just says TODO
 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD
The onboarding doc from three CTOs ago	Shadow spreadsheets quietly running the business	An executive dashboard powered entirely by one intern
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**The quarterly
business review**



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**A mandatory return-to-
office policy**



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Being on camera



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**The all-hands Q&A
nobody submits
questions to**



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**A roadmap with no
dates**



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**Stack Overflow, closed
as duplicate**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**An accepted answer
from 2011 with four
upvotes**



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**A GitHub issue closed
as wontfix**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**An open source
maintainer at their
breaking point**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**The one guy in Nebraska
holding up the internet**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**curl piped straight
into sudo bash**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Reading the
documentation,
eventually**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A Reddit thread that
ended a marriage**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Hacker News explaining
that this is trivial to build**



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"Just use Postgres"



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Someone calling
themselves a thought
leader**



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**A LinkedIn post with one
word per line**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Twitter, or whatever it is
called this week**



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Being ratioed by an intern



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A Discord server with twelve thousand unread channels



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Doomscrolling



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

The algorithm



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A cookie banner with 843 partners



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Accepting all cookies out of pure exhaustion



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

An unsubscribe link that does not



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A captcha asking you to find a bus that is not there



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Proving you are not a robot, to a robot



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**NFTs, remembered
fondly by absolutely no
one**



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**Crypto bros pivoting
to AI**



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**A Web3 startup that is
just a database**



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The metaverse



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**A ninety-minute video
essay about a three-minute
problem**



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Touching grass



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Terminally online
behavior**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**The dark web, which is
mostly just boring**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**An influencer explaining
Kubernetes**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Whatever is in the
unmarked S3 bucket**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

My browser history



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Incognito mode,
which fools nobody**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**What the audit log
saw**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Something you cannot
unsee in CloudTrail**



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**A Slack DM sent to the
wrong channel**



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Reply-all



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**Sharing your screen
with the wrong tab open**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A notification popping
up mid-demo**



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**Unmuting at the exact
wrong moment**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A backup of something
you deleted for a reason**



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**The Zoom background
hiding a crime scene**



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A very long RTO



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Getting throttled



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Aggressive
autoscaling**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A hot standby



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Elastic, in every sense of
the word**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Being generously
provisioned**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A hard dependency

Tight coupling

**Blue/green, if you know
what I mean**



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**Nobody's business but
mine and my SRE's**

Penetration testing

**A YAML indentation
error**



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Tabs

Spaces

**A merge conflict in
package-lock.json**



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**git push --force on
main**



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**Forty-seven commits
titled "fix"**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A rebase gone
horribly wrong**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**The branch named
michael-test-2**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A pull request with four
thousand changed files**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**LGTM, without
opening the diff**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A code review that has
been open eleven days**



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**CI that is red on main
and always has been**



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Flaky tests



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Test coverage at twelve percent	A unit test that asserts true equals true	Staging, which resembles nothing
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A feature flag from 2019 still in the code	Technical debt with compounding interest	The rewrite that will fix everything
 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD	 CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD
Microservices	A distributed monolith	Forty-seven microservices for a CRUD app
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Going back to the monolith

Serverless, which is just someone else's server

Cache invalidation



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Off-by-one errors

Naming things

A race condition that only happens in production



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Heisenbugs

It works on my machine

Shipping the machine



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A retry storm

A thundering herd

**Idempotency,
aspirationally**



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Time zones

Daylight saving time

**UTF-8 encoding,
allegedly**



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**An emoji that crashes
the parser**

**A regex nobody alive
can read**

**Now you have two
problems**



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Legacy code you personally wrote last month



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A comment that says "do not touch this"



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The load-bearing shell script



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A cron job running on someone's laptop



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A Raspberry Pi under a desk running payroll



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A server named after a Lord of the Rings character



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Pets, not cattle



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

An Excel macro doing ETL



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Microsoft Access, the database



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A COBOL system that
has never once failed**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**The mainframe,
quietly winning**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Tape backups



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A floppy disk in a
nuclear facility**



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**Faxing something in
2026**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A PDF that is a scan of a
printout of a PDF**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A vendor appliance that
requires Internet
Explorer**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**End-of-life software with
an active support
contract**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A five-year-old epic
named Modernization**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Lift and shift, then
deep regret**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Repatriating to on-
prem**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**The cloud exit strategy
nobody wrote down**



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Vendor lock-in



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**Multi-cloud, as a
fantasy**



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**Multi-cloud, as an
invoice**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A single point of failure
with an excellent logo**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Active-active, which is
actually active-passive**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Failing over to a region
that is also down**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A DR site with no data in it



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

An RPO measured in vibes



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

An SLA with no teeth



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Service credits worth twelve dollars



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A four-nines promise on a two-nines system



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A status page hosted in the same region



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Monitoring that monitors nothing



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Logs containing everything except the error



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Sampling away the one trace that mattered



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**An alert with no
runbook**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A dashboard with two
hundred panels and no
answers**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Observability,
purchased rather than
achieved**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Datadog's invoice



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Splunk pricing



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**The interview question
about reversing a binary
tree**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Six rounds and a take-
home**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

"We're a family here"



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Unlimited PTO that
nobody takes**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A title bump instead
of a raise**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Being made acting
anything**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A Slack status that says
heads down**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A calendar with no
white space**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Declining a meeting,
bravely**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**The recruiter's quick
chat**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**An interview loop that
ends in a hiring freeze**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A certification that
expires the week you
pass it**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A practice exam harder
than the real exam**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A badge on LinkedIn	Being the only person who read the release notes	Release notes that say "bug fixes and improvements"
A changelog that stops in 2022	Semantic versioning, loosely interpreted	A breaking change shipped in a patch release
A deprecation notice buried in a blog post	The end-of-support date, arriving	Whatever this outage turns out to be

The intern, who was right



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A principal engineer who only communicates in diagrams



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The architect who has not written code since 2014



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A scrum master with a certification and a dream



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The product manager's "quick question"



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Whoever approved this



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

An enterprise agreement signed in a golf cart



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

A vendor bake-off decided before it started



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

The lowest bidder



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A statement of work
written in crayon**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A CAB meeting on
Thursday**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**The audit finding you
already knew about**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A policy written by
someone who has never
deployed anything**



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**A ninety-day security
questionnaire**



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GDPR



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**An air-gapped
environment with a USB
port**



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FedRAMP



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**A government contract
with a 1998 tech stack**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Turning it off and hoping
nobody notices**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Deleting the alert instead
of fixing the problem**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Closing the ticket as
"works as designed"**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Blaming the network
team**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A resignation letter
written at 4 a.m.**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Retiring to run a
bookstore**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**A career in goat
farming**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Becoming a
Kubernetes
consultant**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Turning the incident into
a conference talk**



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**A LinkedIn post
beginning with "I got
fired today"**



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

**Speaking at re:Invent about
a system that no longer
exists**



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**An imposter
syndrome flare-up**



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**Praying to the load
balancer**



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A rubber duck



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Sheer luck



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**The thing that fixed
itself**



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**Nobody knowing why
it works now**



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**Never speaking of it
again**



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